

THE AWAKENARTS PATH

Poetry, Image, and the Practice of Recognition

SUSAN ANN SHEPLER

Language sometimes takes shape before its meaning becomes clear.

QUEEN Ann
runs with sailing fleet of streaming hair,
at midnight from a castle choked in swords and fire;
beyond where kings tamper in bloody schemes for
a kiss of power over anguished queens
and crack metal for gold. Ann
flees a
seized regime
seeking arms and
crests of kings with
chests hearty enough
to save a queen;
and insure safe
return of army
admirals and
cavalries in battle
corners with the king.
Swishes of her hips and
ruffles of her dress scrape
out of sight of hostile ships;
her tattered shoes of satin slip
on mountainous steps of heathen
cliffs. When the night strikes with
silver light her palms shine with dust
and tears, glistening in stars she wears.

THE
DRAGON
FLUNG
its tattered tail,
lined with half-plate armor scales
and struck the hissing furnace head
with smoldering
eyes of
crimson
red. The
dragon flared
green and black
smoking, roaring,
rearing back. And grumbled its weight like an iron crane with
bulldozers rage within its frame, arching breath across the sky
to rear the dragon down one side. Dragon claws scored
and scraped with dragon nails the metal ridges. Both
reckless sin, with cut and slash, dragon wings
were slashed and cracked. The screaming
dragon huffed and burned,
with fireballs the dragon
charged. The lightning
battle tore the night with bolts of hate
in the dragon fight. Morning stepped
with
as eerie sound.
A
dragon lay dead on the
background. A nothing
dragon fought alone
in a dragon fight
with only one
dragon. The
dragon didn't
seem to know
tails and heads
are one somehow.
The shouting sun, the silent moon, the trembling holy stars,
the battle was fought against its parts. The tall huffed
upon the head, the head would see the tall dead.
LIKE TWO SIDES
OF A GOLDEN COIN,
THE PARTS WERE
MADE TO LIVE
AS ONE.
SUSAN ANN
SHEPLER

GRIMMER
G R E E N
Goddess
of eternal
deep
occurs
sleeping in
mindless sleep on
water washed knolls,
far out to sea... where
nighttime fishermen
fear to roll to learn
your mysteries.
'Ere twilight
flares on
GOLDEN WINGS
TO KEEP THE MAIDENS
OF THE DEEP THE DARKEST
OF EMERALD YOUR TAIL BE
SILENTLY WAIVING SILVERLY,
BOUNCING MOONBEAMS
OVER CORAL REEFS. YOUR
FINS FLIP FROM MANGO
TO PARROT GREEN LIKE
PLEATED PAPER FANS.
YOUR PEARLS PARADE
IN CAVALCADES ON
YOUR RONEY TAN.
YOUR HAIR IS
LAD IN GOLD
BRAIDS LIKE
JEWELS ON
THE SAND.
SLEEP, MIDDAND,
SLEEP UNDER
MORNING'S
MISTY VEIL.
YOUR STORY
IS TOLD FROM
TIMES OF OLD
IN THE MARESS'
HEARTY TALES.
BY SUSAN
SHEPLER

When Language Takes Shape

A poem or image can sometimes hold an experience before it can be clearly named. I did not always understand what a piece was carrying when I made it. Only later, returning to it, would something become recognizable.

Recognition matters because an experience can influence us even before we understand or name it. When a poem or image gives that experience a form, we can look at it more clearly and respond with greater awareness. That awareness may open space for understanding, choice, and growth.

A symbol is not an equation with a single answer. A rose might carry love, grief, memory, or several meanings at once, depending on the life that encounters it.

AwakenArts grew from this experience of returning, noticing, and recognizing. A queen fleeing a troubled kingdom, an angel formed through playful words, and a flower shaped from memories of my mother's hands each revealed something through their making. The images did not provide answers. They created places where attention could remain long enough for recognition to occur.

AwakenArts offers a way to notice what is present, recognize what carries personal meaning, and give that recognition a form that can support further awareness and growth.

What Recognition Makes Possible

We may sense or experience something before we have words for it. Myth, poetry, story, and image can make an underlying pattern easier to recognize.

Recognition creates a pause between experience and response. Something that once felt vague, recurring, or difficult to express can be observed more clearly and considered from another perspective.

Looking begins the encounter. Recognition brings something into awareness. Making gives the response a form that can be revisited and carried forward.

This may lead to greater awareness of recurring patterns, language for experiences that have been difficult to express, and a more considered response in place of an automatic one. AwakenArts does not prescribe what an image means or promise a particular outcome. It provides a creative structure for noticing, expressing, and continuing with what becomes personally meaningful.

Seek. Find. Make.

We may sense or experience something before we have words for it. What remains unnamed can still influence how we feel, understand, and respond. Seek, Find, and Make offer a simple way to bring that experience more clearly into view.

Seek creates the pause. Look closely without deciding too quickly what an image must mean.

Find notices what draws your attention, lingers, or connects with something personally recognizable.

Make gives that recognition a form—a word, question, mark, arrangement, image, or other creative response that can be seen, considered, and revisited.

These movements may overlap or lead back to one another. Their purpose is not to produce a correct interpretation, but to move from an unformed response toward greater awareness, understanding, and room for choice and growth.

Poppy



I created *Her Mother's Hands* after my mother died, remembering the poppies on the hills near Susanville where she is buried. I did not plan it, but the poem's leaf shapes came to resemble two hands joined in prayer—echoes of the hands that sewed our clothes and made our quilts. Another viewer may see color, grief, or renewal first; for me, the poem holds my mother's love, still present.

Queen Anne

QUEEN *Ann*
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at midnight *from a castle choked in swords and fire*;
beyond where *kings tamper in bloody schemes for*
a kiss of power *over anguished queens*
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Swishes of her hips and
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her tattered shoes of satin slip
on mountainous steps of heathen
cliffs. When the night strikes with
silver light her palms shine with dust
and tears, glistening in stars she wears.

I wrote *Queen Anne* during a season of real change. Our sons were grown and mostly out of the house, I was struggling in my marriage, and much of what was happening felt beyond my control. Only later did I recognize something of my own search for a way forward in her passage from a troubled kingdom. My faith in God and in Jesus remained the place I could turn—the kingdom that remained. Another reader may notice danger, courage, or escape first; I continue to see a figure between what she has left and what she has not yet reached.

Angel Gardens



Angel Gardens began as wordplay, influenced in part by the rhyme and cadence of Robert Frost's "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening." I wanted the poem to be heard as well as seen. Its lines gradually lengthened into the shape of a dress, placing the angel along an axis between heaven and earth. Another reader may notice the rhyme, puzzle, or garden first; I continue to notice how naturally she inhabits both language and form while still touching the ground.

Observe

Sometimes the simplest way to understand AwakenArts is to spend time with an image. *Ladybug* is offered here without an explanation.

ladybug

A ladybug landed on
my desk needing a stop at a
station or a lighthouse direction
to lead her on her journey. She
breezed in through the window
and walked on fanned papers
of yesterday's poetry.

She was graceful and small
with a little orange body, a dotted
suitcase she carried from place to place.
She settled on one poem, a deep sea fantasy.
I watched her whisk past the title, Wings Under
the Sea, to the beginning: "There are keys tucked
in heart pockets for safekeeping." She eased in gold
keyholes and followed with skipping feet looking for
meaning in keys. "There's a key that sets love
free, and a key for fear's release. She rustled her
way through the poem and hid with "sunfish and
clownfish in ocean silkbonnets." She scurried out
through wilder lands and uncertain endings tufting
her wings like paper leaves. She left the page
with her destiny waiting beyond the
morning and the
dusty velvet
gleam

What do you notice?

What stays with you?

What word, question, mark, arrangement, or image could hold your response?

A Note on AwakenArts

AwakenArts is a creative and educational practice expressed through four connected forms. A **Figure Edition** offers a focused encounter with one visual-poetic figure. Its **Companion** provides space for reflection, writing, and making. An **Edition Print** allows a chosen image to remain present beyond the guided encounter. A **Seek & Find Journal** brings several figures together around a theme through the recurring movements of seeking, finding, and making. The Edition presents the encounter; the Companion supports the response; the print preserves the visual presence.

Susan Ann Shepler is an artist, poet, writer, and the originator of AwakenArts—a body of visual-poetic work shaped through language, image, and symbolic form. She holds a Master’s degree in Counseling Psychology and has pursued further study through the Transformative Language Arts Network and the Center for Journal Therapy. AwakenArts is a way of paying attention, not a set of answers. It offers no diagnosis or promised outcome and requires no particular interpretation. Susan’s own encounters are shaped by her Christian faith. The practice invites each reader to look closely, attend to their own observations, and recognize what provides grounding within their own orientation and experience. To explore the Editions, Companions, prints, and Seek & Find journals, visit awakenarts.com.

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Brief sources: John A. Sanford, *Dreams: God’s Forgotten Language*, rev. ed. (Harper & Row, 1989); C. G. Jung, “On the Relation of Analytical Psychology to Poetry,” in *The Spirit in Man, Art, and Literature* (Princeton University Press, 1966); Robert Frost, “Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening,” in *New Hampshire* (Henry Holt, 1923).